



the Long Walk

There are many reasons why animals migrate. Some do it regularly at certain times of the year. Others do it because their environment has changed and they rarely come back. Not all members of a population migrate—in many cases only those of breeding age go on the move.



Overcrowding

When a population gets too big for the available space or food supply, some have to move away. Locusts and Norway lemmings often form breakaway groups when it all gets too crowded.



I don't know why they're all following me—I have no idea where I'm going!

Finding a mate

Animals that live solitary lives often migrate to find a mate and breed. For two or three weeks a year, millions of red crabs on Christmas Island make their way from their rain forest burrows and walk down to the beach to mate and lay their eggs in the water.



Knowing the way

Some animals travel thousands of miles when they migrate, but many will never have traveled the route before. So how do they know where to go? Animals that make the journey alone inherit this knowledge from their parents. Others, such as geese and swallows, travel together. They navigate using landmarks and the position of the Sun, Moon, and stars. Some birds have an internal compass that picks up Earth's magnetic field.

Nomads

For some animals, wandering from place to place is a way of life. Grazing animals, such as vicuñas, guanacos (pictured), and zebras, are constantly on the move to find new pasture. They don't always travel the same route, they simply go where the grass is.

